

Stills, color ways



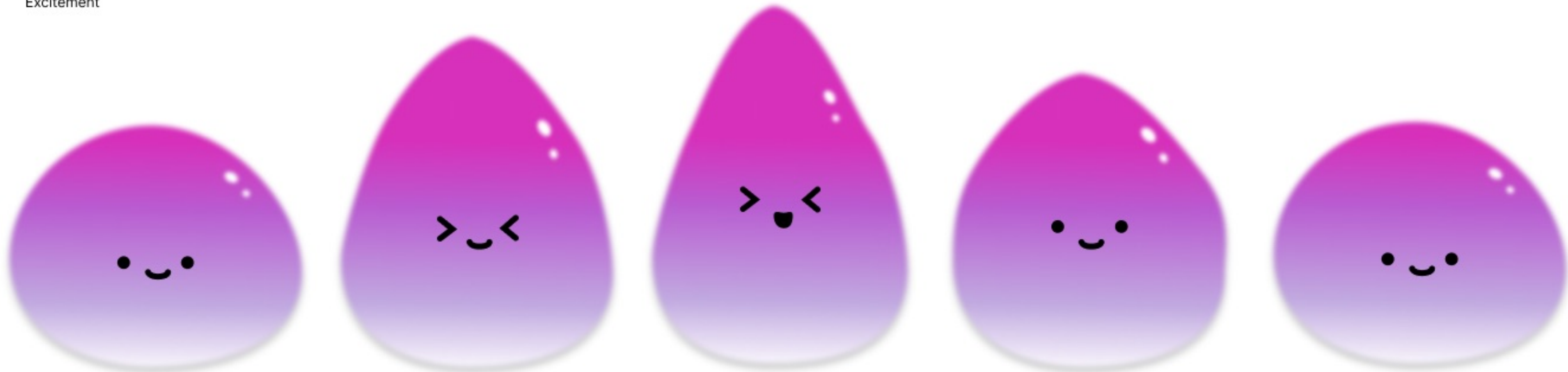
Blob



Looking left and right



Excitement



How it moves





Bean's Garden



- Questions:
1. Can you tell me about a recent time when you felt like you were in an in-between or transitional stage of life?
 2. During transitional periods, did your everyday life feel meaningful on its own, or more like preparation for the next stage?
 3. Do your days ever blur together or feel like they happen on autopilot? What causes that?
 4. Are there small moments in your day that make you feel happy, grounded, or present? Do you usually save them in any way?
 5. What would make it easier or more motivating for you to notice and remember those small moments?

Participant A
Rising second year graduate student

- Questions:
1. Can you tell me about a recent time when you felt like you were in an in-between or transitional stage of life?

I think I am currently feeling like I am in a transitional stage of life. I will be going into the final year of my graduate program soon and am beginning to prepare for full time career search. It feels like I'm transitioning from a student identity to a professional one.

2. During transitional periods, did your everyday life feel meaningful on its own, or more like preparation for the next stage?

I would say that I try to make my everyday life feel meaningful by doing hobbies, but I don't always have the time to do them. I spend most of my efforts preparing for the "next me" or the next chapter of my life mostly.

3. Do your days ever blur together or feel like they happen on autopilot? What causes that?

Yes. I think right now during summer it's less so because I'm currently doing a lot of different projects and my weeks are less structured than compared to during the semester. But when I am at school I sometimes feel bored of doing the same things and going to the same classes and places every single week. I think it's the nature of being in school that cause it and the fact that I'm so caught up in all the tasks that I have to complete that I don't really think about what else there is to do, and also the limited time I have.

4. Are there small moments in your day that make you feel happy, grounded, or present? Do you usually save them in any way?

Yes, I enjoy spending time with my family and meeting my friends whenever we are all available and chatting with them, although recently a lot of the conversations we have I wouldn't say are very present, rather it always seem to be talking about the future and our anxieties. I enjoy hobbies and finding new hobbies as well, I've recently gotten into growing plants.

I don't really document these moments other than taking pictures whenever I remember.

5. What would make it easier or more motivating for you to notice and remember those small moments?

I think like maybe for one a tool that can help me to identify and appreciate the moments while they are occurring so I can become more aware of them. And as for documentation maybe a tool that can help me to easily document but maybe also prompt me to remember certain aspects of my day.

Participant B
Rising second year undergrad student

- Questions:
1. Can you tell me about a recent time when you felt like you were in an in-between or transitional stage of life?

I transitioned from high school to college, which involved living far away from home and adapting to an entirely new lifestyle and environment. Because I went from going to school in China to going to school in the US, a lot of life's aspects were quite different. For example, I had to decide my own sleep schedule, take care of my own chores and food, and also decide whether or not to go to class.

2. During transitional periods, did your everyday life feel meaningful on its own, or more like preparation for the next stage?

I think they feel meaningful on its own, as I'm always learning a lot in transitional periods and discovering new things. For example, going to college taught me how to be more independent and live according to my own schedule. Going to new schools also provides new environments and opportunities, so while I do feel anxious about transitioning sometimes, it doesn't feel like preparation for the next stage of my life. However, the last two years of high school and the college application process did feel like preparing for the next stage, although it's too long for me to classify it as a transitional period.

3. Do your days ever blur together or feel like they happen on autopilot? What causes that?

If I don't have specific goals for the day or anything I need to get done, then days do tend to blur together. For example, summer break can be a blur if there's no homework that needs to get done and no projects that you're working on. With no concrete goal, it doesn't feel like you're making progress in life, which could cause that feeling. However, I don't usually feel like time passes too fast very often, because there are always problems to solve and things to enjoy.

4. Are there small moments in your day that make you feel happy, grounded, or present? Do you usually save them in any way?

I think nighttime walks are a good example, as it just makes me appreciate the world around me and enjoy the din of the city. Going through nature is also nice, and I sometimes feel like Henry David Thoreau. I don't usually save them, since they're common enough. Although I do take photos and journal sometimes, I think of them as medium or large moments.

5. What would make it easier or more motivating for you to notice and remember those small moments?

Mindfulness meditation, as that's a useful practice for increasing awareness and breaking you free from the "autopilot mode" that sometimes happen. For example, you could be scrolling on your phone, realize that you are just looking at a rectangle on your hand with nothing really happening, then go do something else. Doing mindfulness meditation makes these realizations come by more often. Something that could remind me to be mindful, or even guide me though a mindfulness meditation would be quite useful for remembering small moments.

Participant C
Graduate student with one semester left

- Questions:
1. Can you tell me about a recent time when you felt like you were in an in-between or transitional stage of life?

Right now about to graduate soon and about to go into the work-field. Feel like this is a different stage of life with different life styles and different goals, from focusing on what my grades are in school to bigger things like if I'm going to get a proper job. In school it's more subject-based but in school it's a different set of skill sets needed.

2. During transitional periods, did your everyday life feel meaningful on its own, or more like preparation for the next stage?

It feels like preparation for the next stage more. Maybe meaningful on its own on two perspectives, one is I'm preparing for the next stage with ideals for good results and that's meaningful to me, the second is that I am upskilling myself in the process of preoaration and that feels meaningful too.

3. Do your days ever blur together or feel like they happen on autopilot? What causes that?

On some scales yes, the things I'm preparing for finding a job and what I'm learning in school are so different and I feel like I'm not actually learning useful things in school that I actually need to learn. So the gap between my expectations and the reality of things. When you are preparing for the next stage of life, it can feel like the chapter before and the chapter I'm preparing for has a very big gap and I don't know what to do to fill this gap. Hence, the feeling of unsure causing me to not know what to do and feel like I'm loosing agency.

4. Are there small moments in your day that make you feel happy, grounded, or present? Do you usually save them in any way?

Yes, moments in my life such as going out with friends make me feel happy and present but I wouldn't think about it like that when the moment is actually happening so perhaps not that present? But even in those moments I will still be thinking about the future and what will happen. I don't save these moments in any way.

5. What would make it easier or more motivating for you to notice and remember those small moments?

Firstly, knowing what the benefit of noticing small moments is, and secondly making it easy for me to note them down. I feel like I'm a perfectionist and this tool should have low barriers of entry, to make it more about the process than about the end result. For example, I don't take pictures because I feel that the pictures don't turn out "aesthetic" or look good. Therefore, making the function one that doesn't require skill and easy to access would be important for me.

Participant D
Rising 2nd year graduate student

- Questions:
1. Can you tell me about a recent time when you felt like you were in an in-between or transitional stage of life?

Starting internship and getting into the internship, feeling like it's a different stage in life. Realize that she will be back in school very soon, feels like she's in a place to move on but it's strange knowing that she will be back in school. Gives her different expectation about what she wants her last year of school.

2. During transitional periods, did your everyday life feel meaningful on its own, or more like preparation for the next stage?

Kinda both. Trying to do what she's doing everyday to prepare for what she wants. Enjoying what she's doing right now in her internship and think that the company ideals are aligned with her personal ideals. THinks that transitional periods helps her to learn about herself, as long as what she's doing is doing is positive to society, she enjoys it. So she thinks that the things that she's doing are both meaningful and also helps her prepare for the next stage, such as networking. Seeing that. Transition as a person in terms of understanding what her values are in her life. How can I have the power to change my life.

3. Do your days ever blur together or feel like they happen on autopilot? What causes that?

Yes. Caused by repetitive tasks, same structure every day, doing the same tasks, eating same snacks, drinking same matcha. Trying to change it up by small things like changing the matcha recipe, go to take classes for different experiences. Knowing when to rest and shop and do things by herself. These are very accessible for her and easy so she's taking advantage to access these resources to try to stop this feeling of autopilot, changing environments.

4. Are there small moments in your day that make you feel happy, grounded, or present? Do you usually save them in any way?

Matcha, tries to do nice things for people like bringing matcha for her friends, interacting with her co-workers, such as doing personality tasks and doing puzzles, being heard and getting validation from higher ups. Share these moments with other friends, trying to reciprocate the same energy. Don't actually save it but her personality is she doesn't save anything.

5. What would make it easier or more motivating for you to notice and remember those small moments?

The more she do them the more she realize. Or when she receive. How can you bring more kindness into the world. Something that knows big events that comes up in her life, for example a presentation coming up it'll wish you I hope you will have a good presentation, and affirmations afterwards. Knows her schedule such as she had a busy day and be like wow you did so much, good job.

Participant E
Rising 2nd year graduate student with previous work experience

- Questions:
1. Can you tell me about a recent time when you felt like you were in an in-between or transitional stage of life?

Took a gap year before after working her full time previously and joined grad soon. The gap year felt like a life transition for her, at her old job she felt like it was a lot of hard work that had no reward. Everyone envy the people in tech companies and yes you get good money but unsure whether she's truly happy in her life. In gap year learned how to make coffee and got a barista certificate in Copenhagen, trying to explore diversity and experiencing different cultures. And realize that what's important is celebrating and enjoying her life. Want to really impact people in a positive way and to inspire other people. Once she is focused on one project, can't really focus on other things and divide her effort into diverse things. After joining grad school, slowly forget the true goals and what is actually present in her life. Seeing other people pressure her to do things like finding internship. Still thinking about what is right for her but she thinks the gap year helped her to realize what makes her happy.

2. During transitional periods, did your everyday life feel meaningful on its own, or more like preparation for the next stage?

Both, in long term wants to do something that's positively impacting society. As a designer, wondering how she can inspire other people is her current interest.

3. Do your days ever blur together or feel like they happen on autopilot? What causes that?

Yes. Every morning wake up with anxiety and fear of being late, shower, uber to work, lunch from the same place, for now it's enough variety, sit in silence post work. Don't think I'm exhausted from the work hours but more so the people. People don't interact in the elevator and would only turn on their social switch during meeting.

4. Are there small moments in your day that make you feel happy, grounded, or present? Do you usually save them in any way?

Yes, there's another intern that's 10 years younger than her, feels happy talking to him because it feels like talking to a child. Enjoys interacting with people like this, love pure, innocent, genuine people. Takes picture of snacks that intern gave her, couldn't eat it but just kept it on her desk. Whenever work till late and sees sunset takes picture.

5. What would make it easier or more motivating for you to notice and remember those small moments?

Need to be more open-minded and not cynical about the small experiences she's having. Not only focusing on what she likes but also observe others and why people like certain things, appreciating through others' eyes, appreciating what she sees, thinks, eats, hear, appreciating what her loved ones like.

PO Requirements

- a. Onboarding: Pod and Being Introduction
 - i. Users are greeted by a pod in a garden. The interface invites the user to tap the pod. After the user taps it, a small being appears. The user is asked to name the being and enter their own name.
 - ii. The app gives a short introduction: the being is a visitor from another world who has come to learn about the user's world. It grows by collecting small observations from the user's everyday life.
- b. First Daily Quest
 - i. The user is introduced to the core ritual through their first daily quest. The being asks the user to share one thing they like in the physical space around them right now.
 - ii. The user can complete the quest by submitting a short text entry, a photo, or both. This entry becomes the user's first "observation" for the being.
 - iii. Observation Becomes a Seed
 - After the user submits their first observation, the app transforms it into a seed. The being responds happily and acknowledges that it has learned something new from the user's world.
 - iv. A completion message appears: "You completed your first quest. The things you share will help your being learn and grow."
- c. Garden Growth Loop
 - i. The user's observation turns into a seed created that the being plants. Over time, the seed grows into a plant. Different types of observations can eventually grow into different categories of plants, flowers, or visual forms.
- d. Foreshadowing / Habit Preview
 - i. After the first quest, the app explains what will happen next. Tomorrow, the user will receive another daily quest. After a week, they will be able to view a small recap of the moments they shared. Over time, their being and garden will continue to grow from the observations they collect.
- e. Return Logic
 - i. When users come back, they can see how their garden has changed, check on their being, complete a new daily quest, and continue interacting.
 - ii. As plants grow, they can produce flowers or small materials. The flowers can be used as currency to purchase outfits, furniture, or pod decorations.

User Story:

As a [describe the user], I want to [achieve xyz] so that [benefits/why they want to do this]

As someone who struggles to document moments consistently, I want a low-barrier way to record observations through text, photos, or both so that I can save moments without worrying about whether they are aesthetic, important, or perfectly written.

As someone whose days often blur together because of repetitive routines and responsibilities, I want my small daily observations to become visible seeds, plants, or treasures so that I can see proof that each day had something specific and worth remembering.

As someone who feels anxious about the future, I want my collected moments to become a weekly recap or memory library so that I can look back and feel more grounded in the life I am currently living.

Acceptance Criteria

Pod Onboarding

Given the user opens the app for the first time, when the user arrives on the onboarding screen, then a pod appears in the garden.

Introduction

Given the pod appears on the onboarding screen, when the user taps the pod, then a small being appears and introduces itself as a visitor from another world who wants to learn about the user's world.

Naming Setup

Given the being has appeared, when the user is prompted to personalize the experience, then the user can enter their own name and choose a name for the being.

First Daily Quest Prompt

Given the user has completed the naming setup, when a daily quest pop-up icon appears and the user clicks on it, then the being asks the user to share one thing they like in the physical space around them right now.

Quest Completion

Given the user receives the first daily quest, when they submit their first entry, then the app saves the submission and transforms the observation into a seed that can be planted in the garden.

Habit Foreshadowing

Given the user has completed the first quest, when the onboarding experience ends, then the app explains that the user will receive another daily quest tomorrow, can view a weekly recap after several observations, and can continue helping the being grow over time.

Return

Given the user returns to the app after completing the first quest, when they open the app again, then they can see their being, garden, planted seed or plant progress, and the next available daily quest.

Weekly Recap Preview

Given the user has completed at least one quest during the week, when the user logs in at the end of the week, then the being tells the user what it learned from the user's observations that week.

Success Metrics:

Success can be measured by how often users return to the app within a week and complete a daily quest by logging an observation. For the MVP, the target is for users to log at least 3 observations per week. This shows that users are not only trying the app once, but are beginning to build a repeated habit of noticing and recording small moments from their everyday life.

Context

Narrative Identity

https://www.researchgate.net/publication/269603657_Narrative_Identity

- People have the tendency to form identity by creating an internal life story that links their past, present, and imagined future into unity, purpose, and meaning
- “Those who find redemptive meanings in suffering and adversity, and who construct life stories that feature themes of personal agency and exploration, tend to enjoy higher levels of mental health, well-being, and maturity”

Limbo of youth

https://www.ijcms2015.co/file/2024/aijra-vol-9-issue-1/aijra-vol-9-issue-1-8.pdf

- Youth in limbo as a transitional state where young people feel suspended between adolescence and adulthood, with unclear identity, purpose, or future direction
- Causes of this limbo state including uncertainty about the future, identity exploration, educational and career pressure, economic instability, social expectations, technological/cultural change, and delayed milestones
- Impacts: mental health effects such as anxiety, low self-esteem, loneliness, decision paralysis, imposter syndrome, stress, and reduced motivation

Life in Limbo

https://www.jahonline.org/article/S1054-139X(21)00569-3/fulltext

- “Limbo is a place abject of hope, a place where every day looks the same, a place where there is no growth or development beyond what one already knows.”
- A lived-experience, post Covid, focusing on the dull, suspended feeling of not moving forward
- Supports the idea that limbo is not only about big life decisions but more about the everyday experience of sameness, waiting, and feeling cut off from progress

Stats

Quarter-life Crisis Episodes in Emerging Adulthood

https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/21676968251380890

- Quarter-life crisis as an emotionally unstable transition period in emerging adulthood, usually lasting around one to two years
- Across 2,247 participants ages 18–29 from eight countries, self-reported crisis prevalence ranged from 40% to 77%
- The most common external crisis triggers were career transition, financial difficulties, studying-based stress, and family difficulties
- The most common internal experiences were fear/anxiety/worry, negative self-evaluation, sadness, and confusion/uncertainty

Key Milestones for Young Adults Today Versus 30 Years Ago

https://www.pewresearch.org/social-trends/2024/01/25/key-milestones-for-young-adults-today-versus-30-years-ago/

- Young adults today are reaching traditional adulthood milestones in a different order and timeline than their parents’ generation, including education, work, marriage, children, debt, and living arrangements.
- Adults ages 25–29 are more likely to have a bachelor’s degree today than in 1993, with 40% having completed at least a bachelor’s degree compared with 24% in 1993
- Young adults are more likely to carry student loan debt than thirty years ago, among ages 25–29, the share with student loans rose from 28% in 1992 to 43% in 2022
- Marriage and family formation are happening later, among ages 25–29, 29% were married in 2023 compared with 50% in 1993, and young adults today are also less likely to have a child living in their household
- Supports the idea that the “in-between” feeling may be shaped by changing social timelines: young adults are still surrounded by old expectations of adulthood, but the actual path to adulthood has become slower, more expensive, and less linear

Most Young Adults Had Not Reached Key Milestones of Adulthood in 2024

https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2025/08/milestones-to-adulthood.html

- Compares traditional adulthood milestones including moving out of the parental home, working, marriage, and having children, the pathway to adulthood has changed significantly over the past fifty years
- In 1975, the largest share of young adults ages 25–34, 45%, had reached all four milestones: moved out, worked, married, and had children
 - In 2024, less than a quarter of adults in this age range had reached the same four milestones.
- The most common adulthood pathway in 2024 was reaching economic milestones, being in the labor force and living independently, but not necessarily being married or having children
- The article suggests that young adults today may be prioritizing economic security before starting families, especially because of rising costs of housing, food, gas, and other expenses
- Supports the idea that “adulthood” is no longer a single predictable chapter sequence; young adults may feel in-between because social expectations still exist, but actual life paths have become more diverse, delayed, and economically pressured

Mental Health Challenges of Young Adults Illuminated in New Report

https://www.gse.harvard.edu/ideas/news/23/10/mental-health-challenges-young-adults-illuminated-new-report

- Young adults in the U.S. reported high levels of anxiety and depression, with 36% reporting anxiety and 29% reporting depression, which were about twice the rates reported by teens in the same survey
- Nearly 3 in 5 young adults, 58%, reported lacking “meaning or purpose” in their lives
- Half of young adults reported that their mental health was negatively influenced by “not knowing what to do with my life.”
- Major stressors included financial worries, achievement pressure, a sense that the world is falling apart, loneliness, and not feeling like they matter to others

World Happiness Report 2026: Happiness Rankings and Trends

https://www.gallup.com/analytics/349487/world-happiness-report.aspx

- The World Happiness Report uses Gallup World Poll data to compare life evaluations and wellbeing across countries, based on how people rate their lives on a 0–10 scale
 - The 2026 report focuses on happiness across time, countries, and generations, with special attention to social media, social connection, trust, and digital environments
- In the United States, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand, happiness among people under 25 has fallen by an average of 0.86 points on a 0–10 scale over the past 20 years
- In 47 countries, young students who use social media for over seven hours a day have much lower wellbeing than those who use it for less than one hour

2026 Gen Z and Millennial Survey

https://www.deloitte.com/global/en/issues/work/genz-millennial-survey.html

- Deloitte’s 2026 survey finds that Gen Zs and millennials are prioritizing stability, skills, and well-being over fast-paced growth
- More than half of Gen Zs, 55%, and millennials, 52%, say they are delaying major life decisions such as marriage, starting a family or business, or furthering education because of their financial situation
- Many Gen Zs and millennials are making career choices based on long-term fit rather than short-term advancement; only 25% of Gen Zs and 21% of millennials prefer rapid career progression through fast promotions
- Only 6% of Gen Zs and millennials say that achieving a leadership position is their primary career goal
- Supports the idea that young adults may be redefining progress around sustainability and stability rather than traditional timelines

Bad Is Stronger Than Good

https://assets.csom.umn.edu/assets/71516.pdf

- The article argues that negative events generally have stronger psychological effects than positive events across many areas of life, including everyday experiences, major life events, relationships, social interactions, learning, feedback, and memory
- Negative information is often processed more thoroughly than positive information, and negative impressions are quicker to form and harder to change
- The authors suggest this negativity bias may be adaptive because paying attention to possible threats is more urgent for survival than paying attention to possible rewards
- Good can still overcome bad through “superior force of numbers,” meaning repeated positive experiences can matter even if one positive moment may not outweigh one negative moment

Gratitude interventions

The Effects of Gratitude Interventions: A Systematic Review and Meta-analysis

https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10393216/

- Examined scientific evidence on gratitude interventions, using 64 randomized clinical trials
- The meta-analysis found that people who completed gratitude interventions reported greater feelings of gratitude, better mental health, fewer symptoms of anxiety and depression, and more positive mood and emotions
- The article frames gratitude as a practice that can be developed through intentional interventions rather than only as a fixed personality trait
- The authors conclude that acts of gratitude can be used as a therapeutic complement for anxiety and depression and can increase positive feelings in the general population
- Supports the idea that intentionally noticing and recording positive aspects of life may have mental health and well-being benefits

A Meta-analysis of the Effectiveness of Gratitude Interventions on Well-being Across Cultures

https://www.pnas.org/doi/10.1073/pnas.2425193122

- 145 papers, 163 samples, 727 effect sizes, and 24,804 participants across 28 countries
- The study found that gratitude interventions led to small overall increases in well-being, with an overall effect size of Hedges’ g = 0.19
- The effectiveness of gratitude interventions varied significantly between countries, but the study did not find clear cultural factors that fully explained those differences
- Gratitude interventions appeared more effective when well-being was measured through positive affect, when multiple types of gratitude activities were combined, and when randomized controlled trials were used